

ABANDONING THE FOUNDATION

- There are 22 Sainik Schools in 20 states. Conceived in 1961, they were set up by the states and administered by the Defence Ministry and meant to feed recruits into the NDA.
- Diffused responsibility. States pay for the schools' infrastructure, MoD runs them, parents pay teachers' salaries and pensions.
- Increasing fee means children from lower income groups cannot afford the schools. They will fail in their task of providing affordable public school education to the common man.
- Indifference from states. Different states have varying budgetary support. Maharashtra, Kerala and Madhya Pradesh are the biggest defaulters.
- The board of governors of Sainik Schools has not met in the last 10 years "due to lack of agenda."

mon man. Despite the odds, the schools have performed an admirable task of preparing boys for the NDA. From an intake of 16 per cent five years ago, the 22 schools in 20 states contribute nearly 25 per cent of cadets to the NDA and produced its first service head—Army Chief General Deepak Kapoor—and Haryana Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda.

Yet, multiple fee revisions since 1990 mean that the fee of over Rs 50,000 per year has put these boarding schools out of the reach of the common man who it was meant to cater to. Premchandran Pillai, 48, a development officer with the Life Insurance Corporation says he admitted his son Hemant (14) to Sainik School, Kazhakootam, because he wanted him to join the armed forces. "It provides the best physical and mental education for the aspirants of the armed forces," he says. Pillai can pay Rs 55,000 per year as fee, though it is double of what he would pay to a regular school, but worries about an imminent fee hike when the Sixth Pay Commission's recommendations are implemented.

Today, a majority of the aspirants are from the middle and lower middle class of society. An army subedar earning Rs 6,500 per month cannot afford Sainik School fee which can go up to Rs 4,000 per month. "Here lies the dichotomy. Those wanting to join the forces cannot afford the schools, and those who can afford them do not want to join the forces," says a school administrator. "The schools have become backdoor entry points for medicine and engineering aspirants seeking quality subsidised education," rues Commodore (retired) Sudheer Parakala, a student from the first batch of Sainik School, Korukonda.

Chidambaram's one-time grant of Rs 2 crore per school will be used for the improvement of infrastructure but it does not address the root cause of the problem—will parents be able to bear the burden of the increasing fee? Consider the conundrum. The Sainik Schools are owned by the state governments, administered by the Centre but the salaries and pensions of teachers are paid entirely by the parents—something that is unheard of in a Central or even a state government

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